Ensemble Series

UCF New Music Ensemble

Thad Anderson, director

Thursday, November 04, 2021
7:00 PM
Rehearsal Hall

—Program—

Kaleidoscope (2021)	Group Improvisation
Femenine (1974)	Julius Eastman (1940-1990)
Part 1, Build Up	
Part 2, Unison	
Part 3, Create New Pattern	
Part 4, Hold & Return	
Part 5, All Changing	
Part 6, Increase	
Part 7, More Frequent	
Part 8, Mao Melodies	
Part 9, Can Melt	
Part 10, Pianist Will Interrupt	

—Ensemble Personnel—
Joey Baroco, alto saxophone
Jomar Cruz, cello
Leigha Daniels, cello
Isaac Kim, violin
Morgan Magnoni, clarinet
Geordan Raisler, double bass
Maria del Rocio Rosa Rosario, flute
Zachary Schoonmaker, marimba
Kris Zaballero, piano
Thad Anderson, vibraphone

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—Program Notes—

The following is an excerpt from *Julius Eastman, A Misunderstood Composer, Returns To The Light* by Tom Huizenga. It was published by NPR on June 21, 2021.

> There have been many misfits in classical music, but Julius Eastman stands tall among them.
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> In a combustible career, the late composer swerved from critical acclaim to gate-crashing controversy, and from success to homelessness. To be proudly gay as a composer in the 1970s was brave enough; to be Black and gay in that world, even more so. But that confident self-awareness enabled Eastman to write music that was challenging, mischievously irreverent and sometimes ecstatic. Today he's a visionary to many, even if his insistence on incorporating racial slurs into his titles still ruffles feathers.
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> Born in Manhattan in 1940, Eastman was a precocious pianist, blessed with a commanding bass voice. He graduated from the Curtis Institute of Music in Philadelphia, collaborated with key musical figures like Pierre Boulez and Zubin Mehta, and taught at the University of Buffalo. But in the 1980s, after he moved back to New York City, he began spiraling into unpredictable behavior and rumored addiction. When he died in a Buffalo, N.Y., hospital in 1990, he was just 49 years old and alone. His music was scattered to the winds.
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> It's only in recent years that friends and scholars have begun slowly shedding light on Eastman's music and the blurry details of his final, erratic years — and that a newer generation of musicians has given his work a fresh look. Among those is the Los Angeles-based ensemble Wild Up, which has just released a singularly jubilant performance of Eastman's 1974 work *Femenine* (pronounced feh-meh-NEEN), a mesmerizing 67-minute groove that unfolds one beautiful moment after another.
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> Eastman's score for the hour-plus piece is only five pages of manuscript, and the entire work is based around one melodic building block, a two-note theme in the vibraphone that emerges from a forest of bells. For Christopher Rountree, Wild Up's founder and artistic director, that made *Femenine* a kind of creative sandbox for the musicians to play in.
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> "It is a short score," Rountree says. "And one that, maybe because of its brevity, encourages an amazing creative maelstrom. I love that something so gargantuan, like *Femenine,* can come from something so succinct."
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> Composed in a minimalist style for winds, marimba, vibraphone, sleigh bells, piano and bass, *Femenine* was prescient for its day, premiering some two years before Steve Reich's lauded *Music for 18 Musicians*. In Wild Up's freewheeling performance, it sounds as fresh as ever: The group adds a few bells (literally) and whistles, both to Eastman's score and the example set by his own relaxed 1974 recording of the piece.
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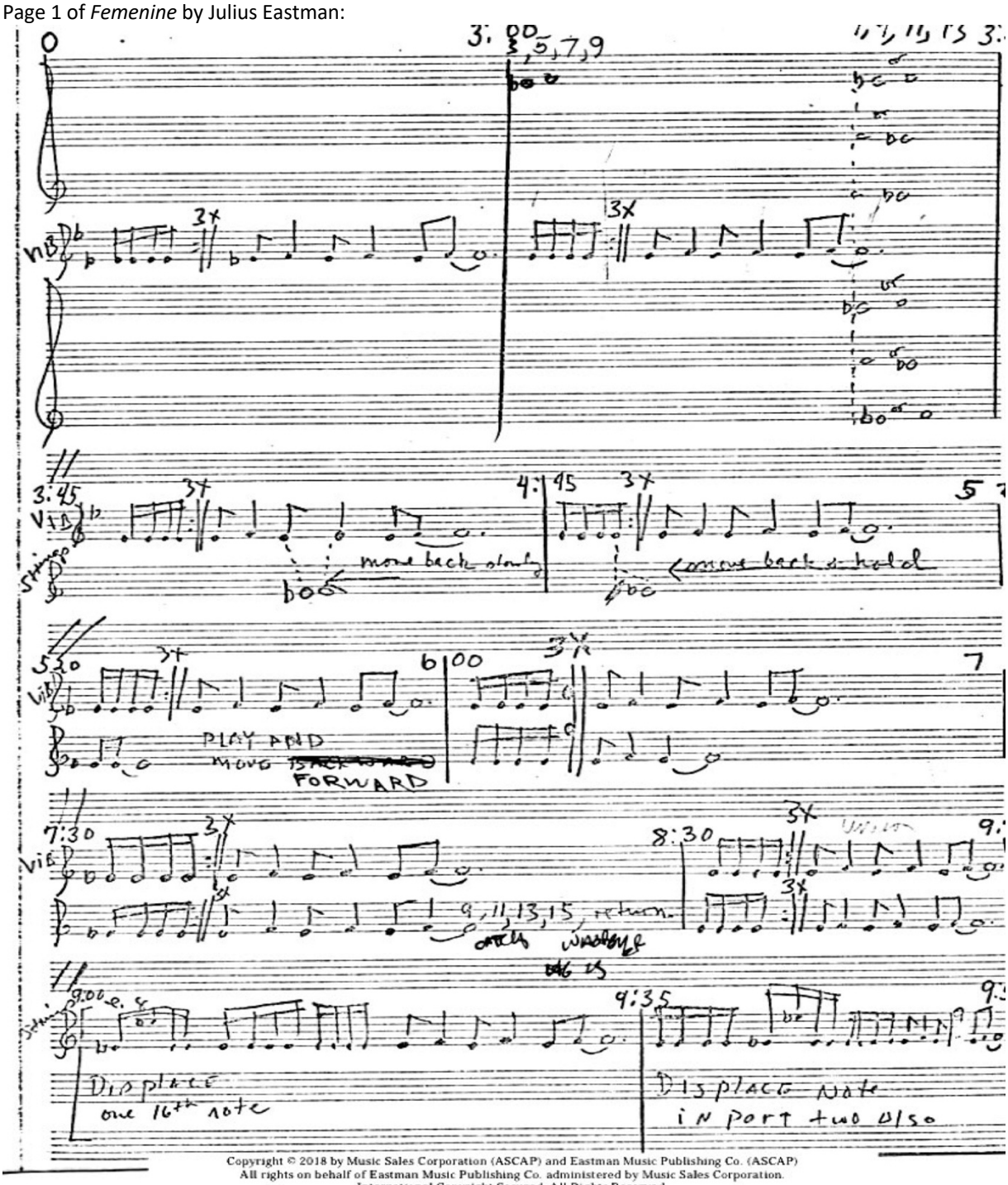
> "The biggest liberty is the inclusion of a dozen or so long solos — all at architecturally significant moments in the piece," Rountree explains. "Most classical players don't grow up improvising, but most of the players in Wild Up are composers and improvisers as well." Along the way, solos pop up for piano, cello, baritone saxophone, flugelhorn and even vocalists — a nod to Eastman's gifts as a singer, which earned him a 1974 Grammy nomination for his arresting performance of *Eight Songs for a Mad King* by Peter Maxwell Davies.

Near the end of *Femenine* comes a characteristic Eastman curveball: From the depths of the roiling ensemble, the hymn tune "Be Thou My Vision" rises momentarily. It's perhaps a foreshadowing of the religious pieces — *One God*, *Buddha* and *Our Father*— that the artist would write near the end of his short and tumultuous life.

To read or listen to the full story, visit the following URL:
https://www.npr.org/sections/deceptivecadence/2021/06/21/1007150496/julius-eastman-a-misunderstood-composer-returns-to-the-light

Page 1 of *Femenine* by Julius Eastman:



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